maintaining that it was necessary to keep this area free from oil companies; more than one analyst speculated that the credit conditions were decisive for the state's choosing the firms' proposal for prospecting in this zone. Because the only company authorised to exploit the ITT block is Petroamazonas, it is important to add to this that it recently incorporated into its Ecuador operations the concept of 'contracting specific integrated services', allowing it to turn over to one company alone practically all petroleum operations (seismic surveys, drilling, crude oil transport, security services, cleaning, etc.), a protocol that could possibly benefit Chinese firms in this block.

Consequences of the new occupation

In this controversial scenario, the Chinese companies' strategy has been to make acquisitions of fields and operations fundamentally in the areas surrounding the Yasuní. The logic of occupying this space and managing these reserves lies in the fact that to exploit them it is necessary to have control over light crude oil reserves, the access roads and the transport required to exploit these areas. These strategies have a double component: on the one hand, the direct purchase of shares and, on the other, the entry into direct contest for fields via direct negotiations with other national companies and via mechanisms that have produced benefits for the Chinese concessions.

Despite the first option of no petroleum extraction, the constant presence of Chinese companies in the Yasuní has lasted. This was patently visible in the change of Block 14's boundaries, which created an oil corridor for the Andes Petroleum company from the potential crude oil storage areas (Eden field) to the ports of the Tiputini. The petroleum companies' operations produced impacts in all its phases. From the actual attendance of community mediators in all stages of the negotiations they created agents of social and environmental pollution. Highways, dirt roads for seismic surveys, and encampments were only some of the problems with which the Amazon peoples have had to cope.

For example, seismic analysis requires the intense and widespread presence of workers. It is an extremely noisy activity since it depends on the use of explosives, motors and chain saws to open dirt roads. The noise drives the fauna away and creates pollution and inconvenience in the zone. For the development of both Block 31 near the ITT and Blocks 14 and 17, complementary surveys have been contracted. Also, in order to exploit the ITT, a new 3D seismic survey would be necessary. Due to the problem of the noise, among other factors, various killings have occurred. The incidents recorded by isolated peoples reveal the pressure their territories suffered. On 26 May 2003 a massacre of the Tagaeri happened under